

6. DEFIANCE:

THE BREACH

The Bolsheviks had found it necessary to make neither ideological nor organizational concessions to the syndicalists in the RILU congress in the summer of 1921. In their minds they had made the one organizational concession necessary much earlier, by constituting the RILU as structurally distinct rather than as a mere section of the CI. Beyond that they had not felt the need, still less the inclination, to compromise any further with their syndicalist interlocutors. From the Bolshevik vantage point the general state of syndicalist-communist relations at the close of the RILU congress offered considerable satisfaction. The trade union International they had envisaged as the means to unite communist trade unions, to link communist minorities in reformist trade unions, and to draw the independently organized syndicalists into Moscow's orbit, had taken the structure and sanctioned the policies they had intended for it. And had not the crucial Italian and Spanish syndicalist delegations been won to the RILU? If some delegations had proved more recalcitrant, would not the CSR adopt the views of the earnest and sensible Rosmer, Godonnèche and Tommasi, and could George Williams possibly be representative of attitudes in the IWW? Had not the NAS delegates and Tom Barker of the FORA, despite their votes against the resolution on RILU-CI relations, professed personal support for the RILU? And if the largest syndicalist organizations and many of the others were virtually won by the RILU, would such renegades as the SAC not choose to follow them in preference to remaining isolated internationally?

But the view of an ascendant Moscow, so attractive and seemingly so well-founded in the summer of 1921, would prove an illusion. With the formation of the RILU the decision of the syndicalists regarding communist internationalism, long deferred, could no longer be postponed. The hopes of the syndicalists, the enthusiasm and expectations they had collectively entertained about Moscow, had been kept alive only because a final accounting with the Bolsheviks had not been made. Now, with the emergence of the RILU, the communists had on the one hand demanded a decision, but on the other - by resolving the organizational issues of the new association solely on their own criteria - they had, as they would learn, not bridged ideological differences but provoked and deepened them. The period from the summer of 1921,

for a year and beyond, would be one of decision for the syndicalists, and, for many, of defiance. Defiance had in fact already begun in the summer of 1921 in Moscow, where syndicalists had challenged the communists not only in the sessions of the RILU congress, only to taste defeat, but also outside the congress, where they had more successfully confronted the Bolsheviks on a practical and moral issue that the Russian Communist Party considered to be of exclusively domestic concern: the fate of a group of Russian libertarians under Bolshevik detention.

Liberating the Libertarians

Most Russian libertarian spokesmen not already imprisoned were taken into custody at the time of the Kronstadt rising in March 1921. A number of syndicalist delegates to the RILU congress learned of these arbitrary imprisonments by making contact with the survivors of such groups as 'Golos Truda' or through conversations with Emma Goldman and Alexander Berkman, who were living in Moscow at the time. Some weeks before the congress convened the issue of political prisoners arose within the French delegation. They decided to raise it with the Russian government. Eager to see the CSR enter the RILU, Rosmer and Tommasi, who hoped to remove the possible obstacle of the prisoners, consented to pursue the question with the Bolsheviks, but their efforts led nowhere.¹ (The two may have been too deferential, perhaps too willing to accept Bolshevik explanations and files at face value. At any rate Tommasi later declared - at the *minoritaire* congress in Lille in July - that he had been shown files in Russia that justified the imprisonment of various Russian libertarians. "To be anti-Bolshevik is to be against the Revolution. I took an interest in the liberation of the anarchists. I saw the dossiers and I must say that if the police did not exist it would be necessary to invent them."²) Since no headway was being made, members of the French and Spanish delegations decided to meet with Feliks Dzerzhinskii, the head of the Cheka, to inquire why certain political prisoners were being held. During the meeting an exasperated Dzerzhinskii at one point observed, "this is the Cheka within the Cheka; you are interrogating me."³ He nevertheless consented to review a list of prisoners, but later responded that each was being held for legitimate reasons. A series of discussions with various Soviet officials were no more successful, and by the time the RILU congress convened the syndicalists' efforts had not progressed, as Leval put it, "by a concession, by a promise or by a hope."⁴

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The question assumed a new urgency when on the eve of the RILU congress thirteen libertarians in a Moscow prison declared a hunger strike. Among the thirteen were such noted figures as Mark Mratchnyi, Voline - earlier the chief editor of *Golos Truda* - and G.P. Maximoff and Efim Iarchuk, both officers of the ARCAS. Incarcerated without charges since March, their protests ignored, the thirteen decided that their last hope lay in dramatically advertising their plight while there were foreign syndicalists in Moscow. They voted unanimously for a hunger strike, and notified the Cheka, the Executive of the Soviet, the Communist Party, and the RILU and CI Executives of their action. The news also reached the syndicalist delegates, who were dissuaded from raising the issue in the RILU congress itself by Russian trade union leaders eager to avoid public discussion of it. Instead, the syndicalists appointed a committee with representation from each interested delegation to broach the subject directly with Lenin.

In the meeting Lenin advanced the customary Bolshevik claim that in Russia only the criminal were imprisoned, the bandits and counter-revolutionaries, and no one was detained owing to ideological differences with the Bolsheviks. He declared himself indifferent to the fate of all political prisoners.⁵ Lenin claimed that the true anarchists in Russia were collaborating with the Bolsheviks and had accepted official posts. He even charged that Makhno's peasant anarchist forces in the Ukraine had allied with Deniken, the White General, against the Bolsheviks in the civil war, more specifically that Voline had assisted Makhno in derailing the trains of the Red Army at a cost of thousands of lives. But while others in the delegation, uninformed about these matters, remained silent, Lenin had not counted on Gaston Leval. Leval and other delegates from Spain had had a long interview with a Red Army General and veteran of the Ukrainian campaign, who dismissed as preposterous the notion that Makhno had ever worked with the Whites. Leval, moreover, had heard Voline's story at first hand. An earlier request of the syndicalists to visit the imprisoned libertarians had been denied, but Leval, invited by Maximoff's wife Olga to risk entry into the prison with visiting relatives, had interviewed Voline at length. He now offered a detailed refutation of Lenin's charges against Voline. As Leval remembered it,

I offered explanations for a quarter-of-an-hour, gave dates, cited facts, names. Lenin listened to me attentively, narrowing his small eyes and elongating his face - which made him look a little like a rat - and stared at me inquisitively. When I had finished, he was visibly baffled. But too cunning to show that he was defeated, he accumulated words, assembled phrases and circumlocutions in order to give himself time to collect his thoughts.

"... Yes, evidently ... if things are as you say, the question presents itself differently ... I will have to ask for additional information on Voline ... I was unaware of these very important details ..."

He continued to twist in his seat, for the problem was, for him, not to yield ground.

But after a few more verbal detours Lenin felt in command of the conversation again. He insisted that the Bolshevik state had to combat its enemies. "Voline is very intelligent, that is why he is more dangerous and we must take the most energetic measures against him," Leval heard with amazement. "For with Makhno he has derailed trains loaded with soldiers of the Red Army, has played the game of the White Generals, of Deniken and Kolchak, hasn't he?" At the end of the nearly three hour discussion Lenin ruled out any consideration of freedom of expression for revolutionary dissidents in Russia, an issue that a number of delegates had raised, but consented to present the question of the hunger-strikers in the Politburo.⁶

The Politburo's response came in a letter to the syndicalist deputation from Trotsky, who suggested that western syndicalists, despite their contributions to the revolutionary movement, failed to distinguish between those Russian anarchists who supported the dictatorship of the proletariat and those who conducted counter-revolutionary activities under revolutionary pretenses. Trotsky insisted that some of the prisoners had committed criminal acts; their release would endanger the lives of communist workers and peasants. "Free from any spirit of revenge" and prompted solely by "considerations of revolutionary expediency," Trotsky nevertheless added, the Bolsheviks consented to release the hunger-strikers, but also insisted upon deporting them.⁷ When the Cheka temporized by denying the presence of anarchists in Russian prisons, the syndicalists compelled the Bolsheviks to consent to another private meeting by threatening to raise the issue in the RILU sessions. Alexander Schapiro had been a leading organizer, behind the scenes, of the intervention of the foreign delegates on behalf of the prisoners.⁸ He and Alexander Berkman were now requested by the hunger strikers to represent them, and together with Leval, Arlandis, Sirolle and Gaudeaux, they met with Lunacharskii in the Kremlin. From the tense meeting came the decision that the prisoners be released and deported, and that their families be allowed to follow them. The agreement, signed by the entire delegation, except by Berkman (himself a deportee from the United States), who objected to its terms and opposed deportation on principle, convinced the enfeebled prisoners to end their fast.⁹

To gain the last word, however, the Bolsheviks themselves dramatically

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breached the agreement not to make the dispute a subject of open discussion in the RILU congress. As the final meeting drew to a close, Lozovskii turned the podium over to Bukharin, who, in the name of the Central Committee of the Russian Communist Party, launched a long and blistering attack on the prisoners in particular, and the Russian anarchists in general, denouncing them as bandits and counter-revolutionary conspirators. This breach of trust together with Bukharin's calumnies outraged the syndicalists and threw the meeting into tumult. The syndicalists nominated Sirolle to respond to Bukharin, but, attempting to squelch any rebuttal, Lozovskii steadfastly refused him the floor. The machinations of the chairman to prevent Sirolle's reply so inflamed the assembly that even some of the Russian communist trade union delegates joined in the syndicalists' protests. That Lozovskii called in a detachment of Red Army soldiers to quell the disturbance only further incited the delegates and heightened their protests. After thirty minutes of virtual chaos Berkman braced himself for a rush on the platform, but a vanquished Lozovskii now agreed to take a vote on whether a reply should be heard. The majority demanded that the floor be given to Sirolle, who denounced the duplicity of the Bolsheviks and rebutted Bukharin's attack on the anarchists. Sirolle invited the assembly to hear Schapiro put the case of the Russian syndicalists, but Schapiro was not allowed to speak.¹⁰

A number of the syndicalist delegates who remained in Moscow following the congress continued their efforts on behalf of the prisoners, though some, notably the Spanish delegation with the exception of Leval and Hilario Arlandis, dissociated themselves from this undertaking following Bukharin's open attack on the anarchists. Those still committed to the cause wondered whether after their departure the prisoners would be released at all. They decided to broach the issue when Trotsky paid a social visit to the French delegation. Trotsky responded by berating them angrily for wasting their time by intervening on behalf of the libertarians, by whom they had been deceived, when their overriding duty had been to demonstrate confidence in the Soviet government. He nevertheless assured the delegates, their smiles now manifestly forced, that the prisoners would indeed be deported. But Leval found this too vague. Backed by Arlandis, he requested further details. "I then witnessed the finest and most hideous explosion of anger that a tyrant can exhibit," Leval recorded.

Trotsky drew himself up to his full height, fully expanded his chest, raised his head, lifted his arms while clenching his fists, and, in an outburst of fury, nearly screamed at me:

"Who are *you* to ask me, *me*, who doesn't know you, when I will act on the decisions I have made?"

Then, taking me by the lapels of my jacket, he added, still in the same manner: "We made the Revolution, we Bolsheviks, and what have you done? It is not for you to give us orders; we don't have to take them from you!"¹¹

In September the prisoners were released, as promised; the expulsions began in November. For the first time, the Russian workers' government began deporting revolutionaries. The majority of the men and their families were expelled in January. Supplied with the passports of Czechoslovakian prisoners-of-war and sent to the West, they were refused entry at the German border. They gained admission only when Fritz Kater intervened to accept responsibility for them, on behalf of the FAUD.¹² The refugees later established a Russian anarcho-syndicalist organization-in-exile, and their spokesmen such as Maximoff, Mratchnyi, Iarchuk, and above all Alexander Schapiro who later joined them, became strong supporters of the formation of a syndicalist International.

But aside from the galling episode of the hunger-strikers, the Bolsheviks had good cause to be content with the RILU congress. They had every reason to believe that they had secured the allegiance of the largest syndicalist bodies, those of Spain and Italy, that they would win the French CSR as well, and that some of the smaller organizations such as the Dutch NAS would soon come into the fold; in short, they had every reason to believe that their ideological and organizational victory over the syndicalists had been all but complete. That sense of victory soon proved largely groundless.

Repercussions of the RILU Congress

News of the decisions of the RILU congress elicited a storm of protest from the syndicalist movement in the West. In France in mid-July, the CSR immediately and publicly disavowed Godonnèche and Tommasi for having exceeded their mandate by signing the resolution on RILU-CI relations.¹³ On the same grounds Tommasi had to resign his position as Secretary of the *Union des Syndicats de la Seine*. An inter-union committee of Spanish speakers in France denounced the Spanish delegation as having betrayed the CNT.¹⁴ From Moscow Lozovskii expressed his astonishment that *La Vie Ouvrière* would publish such a document, and Arlandis complained even more bitterly, declaring that the French

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should have awaited the passage of the Spanish delegation through Paris or word from the CNT's National Committee.¹⁵ But when the CNT spoke two weeks later its statement could not have afforded Arlandis much comfort. An extraordinary CNT plenum held in Madrid in August decided to await the return of the Spanish delegates before judging their conduct in Moscow, but it also forcefully reaffirmed the categorical national and international autonomy of the CNT *vis-à-vis* all political parties, and specifically the communist party.¹⁶ In the longer run few syndicalist organizations escaped a prolonged internal controversy concerning the RILU, a dispute particularly pronounced in France, Italy and The Netherlands. In the midst of these disputes the German syndicalists, with support from members of the IWW, the USI and the CSR, acted to unify the opposition to Moscow.¹⁷ The first national congress of the FAUD to follow the RILU assembly met in Düsseldorf in October. A number of fraternal delegates – Bernard Lansink Jr. of the NAS, R. Casparsson of the SAC, and George Williams of the IWW – joined representatives of the FAUD in calling upon the International Syndicalist Bureau to convene an international syndicalist congress. They declared this step to have been necessitated by the failure of the RILU congress to establish a labour International free of political influence. They also specified that the first five points of the Berlin Declaration serve as the basis of the proposed congress.¹⁸

Although the USI soon endorsed the Düsseldorf proposal by telegram, the international question was actually far from resolved within the Italian organization. Nicolo Vecchi and Lulio Mari had returned to Italy intent on persuading the USI to accept the Moscow decisions.¹⁹ The resolution binding the RILU to the CI, as well as the RILU's expectation that the USI join the CGL (if the CGL entered the RILU) and closely collaborate with the *Partito Comunista Italiano*, however, appalled the USI Executive. In October 1921, just prior to the Düsseldorf meeting of the FAUD, the USI Executive met in Milan to discuss the international issue. Vecchi recommended that the USI join the RILU and that it cooperate fully with the PCI. The Executive demurred, endorsing instead Armando Borghi's proposal that the USI support the RILU only if another congress held outside the Soviet Union debated the RILU-CI relationship anew, a demand already advanced by the French CSR. The Executive also approved a resolution from Alibrando Giovanetti and others insisting upon the complete autonomy of the USI. Subsequent discussions between Borghi, Giovanetti and Gervasio of the USI Executive, and representatives of the PCI and the RILU, failed to alter the position of the USI.²⁰ Undaunted, Vecchi turned to

the offensive. In Verona in December, with funding from Moscow, he launched a new newspaper, *Internazionale*, with which to campaign against Borghi and drum up support for the RILU.

Vecchi carried his campaign to capture the USI for Moscow to the fourth USI congress in March 1922, in which the international question dominated. Moscow attempted to buttress Vecchi's position. Lozovskii, the head of the RILU, wrote to the assembly that any uncertainty within the USI regarding the RILU could only rest on a misunderstanding, for the subordination of the unions had neither been intended nor established by the linkage between the RILU and the CI. Only Moscow's labour International could unite all revolutionary unions against the bourgeoisie. Lozovskii cajoled the delegates. "Your fine tradition of struggle, your combative spirit, your earlier adherence to the Third International," he wrote, "gives you the right to a place of honour" within the RILU. But the delegates also heard from another Russian who counselled against affiliation with what he dismissed as a party-dominated RILU. Alexander Schapiro wrote to assert that the RILU grouped on the one hand Soviet trade union organizations, whose officers were all members of the communist party and received their instructions from it, on the other, minorities of reformist unions outside Russia, cell groups controlled by national communist parties commanded, in turn, by the Russian party. Schapiro warned the Italian syndicalists to "entertain no illusion: the trade union International of Moscow is the illegitimate daughter of the Communist International, and consequently the handmaiden of the Russian Communist Party."²¹

But the Italians needed no outside intervention to ensure a lively discussion on the international question. Borghi, now explicitly attacking the Soviet regime and dismissing the RILU as no more than an appendage of Bolshevik state power, called for an autonomous syndicalist International. Vecchi defended the RILU, but against him Giovanetti proposed reaffirmation of the traditional principles and methods of syndicalism, especially the absolute autonomy of the unions, and the repudiation of the RILU as strictly subordinate to the communist party. He also stipulated the conditions that the USI should require of a labour International, among them a commitment to direct action, a rejection of any connection with the CI, and the exclusion of minority groups from reformist union organizations affiliated with the Amsterdam International. Giovanetti's resolution defeated Vecchi's by a ratio of four-to-one. The assembly also endorsed Borghi's rider that the next RILU congress be held outside Soviet territory and similarly that its future

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Executive sit outside Russia. The decisions drew the wrath not only of *Internazionale*, but of Lozovskii as well.²²

Lozovskii could not resist the temptation to credit the defiance of the Italian and various other syndicalists to French inspiration. Citing the resolution endorsed by the USI Executive in October as a "brilliant example," Lozovskii in a letter to Rosmer in November remarked: "What hash the French syndicalists have planted in the skulls of the syndicalists of other countries." Lozovskii also attributed to the position taken by the French signs of resistance to the RILU in Latin America. He continued: "The mistrust that already existed increases. The German syndicalists also attempt to turn the erroneous position of the French to advantage; they have taken it into their heads to found in Düsseldorf their Syndicalist International."²³

But Lozovskii, who had his own reasons for pointing an accusatory finger at the French, manifestly exaggerated the role they played in eliciting opposition to the RILU. Certainly Gallic opposition should not be linked so directly to that later expressed by the USI or the CNT. The Spaniards, far from being inspired by the example of the French response, appear quite consciously to have declined to follow it. The *cenetistas* had grounds at least equal to those of the French *minoritaires* for immediately disavowing members of their delegation. But in the face of the early news from Moscow, the CNT plenum of August 1921 was content to reiterate the traditional position of the CNT, postponing any further decisions until the Spanish delegates returned. In October another plenum, upon hearing Maurin's report, referred the entire matter to local union discussion. As familiarity with the RILU program spread, resistance to Moscow mounted, greatly and perhaps decisively reinforced by the appearance of Pestaña's critical report. In this process the reaction of the French *minoritaires* was not a primary, but a secondary, perhaps a tertiary consideration. And the same, ultimately, must be said of the responses of syndicalist and industrialist organizations elsewhere, in Italy or Sweden, the United States or Argentina, which began to express opposition to the RILU. The French example could not have deepened the already profound resistance of the FAUD and the SAC. Nor did the various revolutionary unions being asked to disband by Moscow, the IWW for example, require French inspiration to express opposition. However much interest the various syndicalist and industrialist organizations took in one another's response, however much some of them may have applauded the French reaction, their decisions were primarily domestic responses to the one new, overwhelmingly important and crucial external factor that confronted each of them: the newborn RILU,

the character it had now adopted, the policies it had now embraced. Judgment could no longer be postponed. All syndicalists and industrialists who had been able to keep their enthusiasm for Moscow alive, or perhaps merely their options open, by shifting their attention from the CI to the proposed RILU, now faced an inescapable choice: to submit, to defy, or to call for revisions. A decision, long deferred, was now demanded of them.

In short, the formal constitution of the RILU, the bearer and agent of Bolshevik policies in the trade union movement, crystallized syndicalist opposition to Moscow in the summer and autumn of 1921. The French responded to these policies first (setting aside the expression of dissent by syndicalists and industrialists of various nationalities in Moscow during and after the RILU congress itself), in part because of the impending annual CGT congress. But the first response should not be seen as a catalyst for those that followed. There is no reason whatever to suppose that a later or different response by the French *minoritaires* would significantly have altered or delayed the responses of the CNT, the USI, the IWW and the others. Lozovskii was no doubt disappointed by the sobering realization of widespread syndicalist repudiation of the RILU program, as symbolized by the initial *minoritaire* response in Paris and confirmed by the USI's decision in October, particularly in view of the Bolsheviks' optimism at the close of the RILU congress. And he clearly had grounds to anticipate a more favourable response in Italy and Spain. Various factors - repression, organizational peril, sheer reluctance - had kept Borghi and Pestaña from fully voicing their doubts about communist internationalism earlier. The USI and the CNT were putative members of the CI. Their delegations had left Moscow favourably disposed towards the RILU. But the more germane and important point is that Lozovskii was hardly likely to offer the most direct and obvious explanation for widespread and growing resistance to the RILU: that the policies with which the Bolsheviks had endowed it, had elicited opposition from many such organizations, of which the CSR was but one. However much international influence Lozovskii may sincerely have believed the French to possess, to regard them, as he put it, as having sown "an unimaginable confusion in the minds of the syndicalists of all countries,"²⁴ conveniently shifted responsibility to the doorstep of the French, and masked the more unpalatable fact that a series of syndicalist organizations found the policies of the RILU unacceptable quite independently of the French.

As for the domestic significance of the sharp reaction of the CSR in mid-July to the policies endorsed by the RILU - their disavowal

of Godonnèc, between the formal linkage of the *minoritaires* the signatories *minoritaires*, from such membership revolutionary ranks. Gaston Monnès that the document of revolution *minoritaires* 1920.²⁵ But the mandate about collaboration oppose reciprocal Godonnèc and for while *en* instructions to regard as it, "the minority's." Ro delegation, definition of the but it was not explicitly. The ration indicated they collectively congress, and that the CSR for widespread no doubt also message of the party - victory in the CGT the month.

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of Godonnèche and Tommasi, their repudiation of any close connection between the unions and the *Parti Communiste Français*, and of the formal linkage of the RILU to the CI – did it mark the reunification of the *minoritaires*, but on the platform of the pure syndicalists? Certainly the signatories of this declaration covered the entire spectrum of *minoritaires*, from such staunch libertarians as Quinton and Verdier to such members of the *Vie Ouvrière* faction as Monatte and the revolutionary railwaymen and earlier impassioned partisans of Moscow, Gaston Monmousseau and Pierre Semard. It has been noted, moreover, that the document made no reference to the possibility of collaboration of revolutionary unions with political organizations, a position the *minoritaires* had endorsed at the CGT congress of Orléans in October 1920.²⁵ But the silence of the CSR on this point was not new. Indeed, the mandate of the CSR's delegation to the RILU congress said nothing about collaboration. Rather, it specifically required the delegates to oppose reciprocal representation between the RILU and the CI. Godonnèche and Tommasi certainly recognized this qualitative difference, for while *en route* to Moscow the two agreed not to honour the instructions under which they had been dispatched, choosing instead to regard as "our mandate, the only valid one," as Godonnèche put it, "the minority resolution of Orléans, which provided for 'collaboration'." Rosmer also deplored the instructions given to the CSR delegation, denouncing them as "ridiculous."²⁶ The dramatic repudiation of the RILU policies by the *minoritaires* may capture attention, but it was not the first time the CSR had failed to sanction collaboration explicitly. That such diverse *minoritaires* could sign the CSR's declaration indicates, first, the nearly universal dismay and disappointment they collectively felt, despite their differences, at the results of the RILU congress, and, second, that most *minoritaires* understandably expected that the CSR's instructions would be observed. An additional motive for widespread support for the declaration was that the *minoritaires* no doubt also felt the need to dissociate their movement from the apparent message of the RILU congress – the subordination of the unions to the party – which the *majoritaires* would surely invoke against them in the CGT's annual congress, due to convene in Lille at the end of the month.

The fact is that the *minoritaires'* response to the RILU congress simply did not reunite them on the platform of the pure syndicalists. It united them in their opposition to the RILU as originally constituted. And it strengthened the hand of the libertarians within the CSR, in part because the communist-syndicalists were quite weak within it, more

so because the more important sector headed by the *Vie Ouvrière* group remained disheartened and disoriented following the RILU congress. The decisions taken in Moscow, in short, suddenly transformed the situation among the *minoritaires*, but it did not unite them, as events quickly demonstrated. The pre-Lille meetings of the *minoritaires* were hardly characterized by unity and harmony. *Le Libéraire* observed that "profound disagreement" existed among the delegates at the start of the meetings, that rumours flew, that sharp accusations threatened to "divide irremediably the revolutionary opposition." It added that "for fear of converting a congress into a washhouse, they dare not launder the dirty linen." Similarly, *Le Libéraire* noted "such divergences of ideas" near the end of the meetings that agreement on a single minority resolution appeared unlikely. The delegates eventually settled on a joint resolution, but one that embodied the goals of revolutionary syndicalism, *Le Libéraire* wrote, only thanks to the mighty struggles of Louis Lecoin (a member of the resolution committee and a leading libertarian, himself a stalwart of *Le Libéraire*), and one from which, it complained, Monatte had successfully kept the word "federalist." This is not the report of a unified opposition.²⁷

Not without difficulty, the minority had endorsed a single resolution that even the pure syndicalists regarded as a compromise. Unsettled and dispirited by the RILU decisions, the *minoritaires* advanced a resolution within the CGT congress that reaffirmed the complete national and international independence of the unions from all political groups, and demanded the departure of the CGT from the IFTU and the International Labour Office of the League of Nations. On the positive side it did no more than suggest that the CGT's affiliation with the RILU - "on the express condition that its statutes respect the autonomy of the syndical movement" - would not violate the *Charte d'Amiens*.²⁸ The *minoritaires* had been making headway within the CGT despite the authorization extended by the Confederal Committee, as early as November 1920, to expel CSR members. By early 1921 only a few federations, such as agriculture, mining and textiles, had taken that drastic step. The *minoritaire* advances had continued. In May, the desperate majority on the Confederal Committee moved the annual congress up to July, for fear that the *minoritaires* would have prevailed by the original congress date in September. Between May and July the CSR showed steady gains in a series of meetings of departmental unions and federations, preliminary to the CGT's annual congress. The *minoritaires* had been particularly bolstered by victories in the important federations of construction workers and railwaymen.²⁹ In the Lille

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congress, however, the threat of union subordination to Moscow proved a powerful and much needed weapon for the *majoritaires*. After extraordinarily bitter and tumultuous sessions, in which one overwrought orator fell dead at the lecturn, and which witnessed flying chairs, brawls and gunfire, the *majoritaires* carried the day. But the narrow margins of their victories, on the issues of the general orientation of the CGT (1556 to 1348) and of international policy (1572 to 1325), illustrated their tenuous hold on the Confederation.

The *majoritaires* could so effectively invoke the spectre of Moscow's threat to the trade unions in part because so many *minoritaires* could only grudgingly agree that the RILU statutes apparently embodied such subordination. The minority resolution at Lille had amounted to a demand that the RILU alter its existing statutes to salvage syndical autonomy. Monatte had publicly lamented, prior to the Lille congress, that the Russians "find liaison and subordination necessary," an attitude that the syndicalists could not possibly accept in a trade union International. Monatte located the Bolshevik "preoccupation" with subordination in the "old social democratic conception of the role of the trade unions, of their revolutionary inferiority." But it had been the general experience of labour militants in France that the unions were far more revolutionary than purportedly revolutionary parties. Monatte reflected this view by writing that while the communist party would never lead the unions in France, he hoped that it would enter the struggle alongside them. French unionists still sympathized with Moscow, Monatte insisted, but he warned that a labour International must be established that could encompass all revolutionary unions, lest each revolutionary movement attempt to found its own.³⁰

The Bolsheviks, for their part, continued to deny that they intended any subordination of the unions. They had permitted an organizationally distinct RILU to be established, in large part to placate those who insisted upon syndical autonomy. Some communists extended the obviously false equation of organizational separateness with autonomy to the relationship of unions and party. Even before Monatte's article appeared, indeed, even before the *minoritaires* had learned the results of the RILU congress, Trotsky, the leading spokesman on French affairs within the Bolshevik leadership, wrote Monatte to explain that the communists intended that the unions remain autonomous:

It is not a matter of subordinating the unions to the party, but of the merger of revolutionary communists and revolutionary syndicalists in the cadres of a single party, and of a concerted centralized labour of all the members of this unified party, within the trade unions which remain autonomous, an organization independent of the party.³¹

Whatever Monatte may have thought of an argument that conflated structural separation and autonomy, Moscow provided in the same month a more frank and detailed illustration of its conception of party-union relations, in a private communication from the Executive Committee of the CI to the leadership of the *Parti Communiste Français*. Writing after the sharp response of the *minoritaires* to the RILU congress, Zinoviev observed that "if Monatte and Monmousseau persist in their current position, we will no doubt end with the formation of a little Two-and-a-Half trade union International, between Amsterdam and Moscow." The CI Executive instructed the PCF to register its members in the unions, and to keep them and the party's local organizations under the systematic control of a committee established by the party for this purpose. An accompanying resolution from the CI Executive observed that in addition to the party's public efforts to win the unions, "secret action will be exercised in particular to facilitate the accession of communist militants to the responsible offices of the unions." It insisted that the PCF require any eligible member to join a union and to adopt within it "the attitude commanded by the party."³²

Following the congress in Lille, the CSR reiterated its decision to defer affiliation with the RILU until Moscow recognized "without restriction the complete independence and absolute autonomy of French syndicalism and of the trade union International." It did so despite – in fact in response to – the belated expression of the support for the RILU by a number of CSR delegates, still in Moscow. Alarmed by the initial response of the *minoritaires* in France to the RILU congress, the Bolsheviks had won this concession from the French delegation.³³ They also clearly orchestrated a campaign by such foreign syndicalists as Tom Mann, George Andreytchine, and Andres Nin, who denied that the resolution on RILU-CI relations threatened union autonomy, to convince the CSR to change its position. The CSR Executive declined, however, to send a delegate to the RILU Executive, and called for a second international labour congress to consider the issue anew.³⁴

The attention of labour activists in France remained rivetted to the domestic drama. Following the Lille congress, the *minoritaires* continued their campaign of opposition, while the *majoritaires* were prepared to expel dissidents from the CGT. Increasing numbers of unionists on both sides regarded a split as inevitable. It came at the end of the year. In the following months the leaders of the CSR devoted themselves to building up a new confederal organization, the *CGT Unitaire* (CGTU), which by mid-1922 could claim more members than its spurned

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parent organization. The libertarians, who earlier led the CSR, now dominated the leadership of the infant CGTU.³⁵ Their initial ascendancy came both through their own efforts and through the indecisiveness of the pro-Moscow faction, following its temporary rift with the Bolsheviks. The Bolsheviks themselves were doubly dismayed; not only had a schism not been avoided, but the attitude of the new CGTU could scarcely be welcomed in Moscow. When, for example, the Administrative Committee of the CGTU formally condemned "violence that does not have as its goal to defend the revolutionary conquests of the proletariat, which it confuses with no government or party," it obviously had in mind the Bolshevik persecution of Russian revolutionaries. To remove all doubt about its own position, the Committee declared French syndicalism to be "anti-statist by essence and by definition," and the unyielding opponent "of every form of government, whatever it may be."³⁶ When Lozovskii appealed to the CGTU in March 1922 to send representatives to Moscow to help prepare the second RILU congress, moreover, the CGTU declined, replying that it would instead send a delegation to the Berlin syndicalist conference organized by the FAUD, now scheduled for June.³⁷

The RILU had earlier received equally sharp rebuffs elsewhere. In compliance with the Berlin Declaration the Swedish SAC had participated in the RILU congress. But the critical position adopted by the SAC, along with the FAUD, in Berlin in December 1920, had provoked the ire of the Bolsheviks. In Moscow the Bolsheviks continued their campaign. Zinoviev, in the third CI congress, assailed the German syndicalists and characterized those of Sweden as "typical Centrists, wobbling between Moscow and Amsterdam."³⁸ Despite the participation of the SAC in the syndicalists' Düsseldorf meeting, the RILU continued its overtures to the Swedes. In December 1921, it asserted that those who had not yet accepted the necessity of proletarian dictatorship were "prisoners of antiquated formulas." To attempt to found a syndicalist International, Lozovskii warned, would be to declare war against Moscow. But to remain without international links would constitute "suicide" by the Swedish syndicalists. Thus, the only realistic option open to the SAC would be to enter the RILU. The SAC Executive responded that Lozovskii deluded himself by claiming a majority of syndicalist support for proletarian dictatorship. The relationship between political parties and unions stipulated in the RILU's statutes "transgresses fundamentally against the essential principles of syndicalism. Such a connection is unacceptable to us under any circumstances."³⁹ Some months later (May 1922), the Executive declared that

if the SAC's next congress upheld the organization's declaration of principles, "the question of affiliation with the RILU falls automatically." That only five of its 425 local organizations had declared in favour of Moscow, and then only if the remaining European syndicalists also adhered, indicated the meagre support the RILU had won within the SAC.⁴⁰

The results of the RILU congress similarly triggered controversy within labour organizations in the Americas. In Canada, Gordon Cascaden opened his lengthy and hostile report on the proceedings with these words: "Seldom is it the sad duty of a delegate to report on the birth and death of a labour organization at the same time."⁴¹ In the United States the IWW, and in Argentina the FORA, repudiated the RILU before 1921 drew to a close. Misled and alarmed by reports of the Düsseldorf conference, the IWW, which had yet to consult with its delegate to Moscow, wired a disclaimer of efforts to form a second trade union International. But after studying George Williams's report and examining the documents of the Moscow congress, the IWW Executive declared affiliation "with this so-called International" to be "not only undesirable but absolutely impossible." In explanation the Executive cited the unrepresentative nature of the RILU congress; its express condemnation of IWW policies; its approval of 'boring within' tactics; the political character of the RILU ("in fact the Communist Party, thinly disguised"); and the impossibility of collaboration between the IWW and the communist party. Although it rejected the RILU, the Executive nevertheless invited "proposals for international affiliation that are not in conflict with our principles and policy, and do not call upon us to sacrifice our autonomy."⁴² The Argentinians of the FORA indicated their displeasure with the Moscow decisions by warmly welcoming, in *La Protesta*, the call for a syndicalist congress emanating from the FAUD's Düsseldorf assembly, by vigorously criticizing the politicized RILU, and by openly repudiating Tom Barker, who had carried the FORA's mandate to Moscow.⁴³

"The Olive Branch, the Bloody Sword": Towards Schism

Throughout 1922 relations between Moscow and the syndicalists of most countries deteriorated, and they did so, ironically, at a time when the CI was introducing a new policy aimed at overcoming divisions within the labour movement: the united front. As so often thereafter, the introduction of new policy within the CI reflected changes in Bolshevik

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domestic and foreign policy. The revolution in the West that the Bolsheviks had once regarded as the key to the survival of that in Russia had not come. By early 1921, when the threat of foreign intervention and White victory in the Russian civil war had receded, the Bolshevik government faced massive discontent with the measures of war communism from workers – unmistakably expressed in the Kronstadt rising of March 1921 – and more importantly, from the vast majority in the country, the peasantry. Though distasteful to many communists, the partial reintroduction of capitalism in the form of the New Economic Policy, in March 1921, constituted a strategy for defusing such discontent, for reviving a shattered economy, above all for placating the peasantry, and in effect overcoming the isolation of the Bolshevik party and government in Russia. Similarly, the fact that revolution had not come elsewhere now prompted the Soviet state, the sole socialist state in a hostile world, to attempt to overcome its international isolation, to seek to normalize diplomatic relations and economic ties with the imperialist nations.

The united front policy embraced by the CI represented an effort to overcome another form of communist isolation: that of the communist parties outside Russia. In this respect it constituted “an implicit admission” that the CI “had been founded on a misconception.”⁴⁴ When the CI had been established in the post-war revolutionary climate of 1919, the Bolsheviks had assumed that revolution in the West was imminent, that the inherently revolutionary workers, if only separated from their socialist leaders, the traitors of 1914, would extend the revolution well beyond Russian borders. The CI would oversee the break with the socialist traitors and guide and encourage the revolutions from afar. By the second CI congress in 1920, the Bolsheviks were convinced that world revolution would involve a longer struggle than anticipated, and set about fashioning the purified, disciplined communist parties that they now deemed a prerequisite to revolution. By the third CI congress in 1921 the Bolsheviks acknowledged that the post-war revolutionary tide had crested and ebbed. The working masses had obviously not rallied wholesale to the revolutionary cause. The communist parties called into being outside Russia, founded in a climate of revolutionary optimism, were far from heading the wider workers’ movement; rather, they remained isolated from it, small, often demoralized parties, a disorganized revolutionary officer corps without an army. Nor did it appear that the policy of penetrating and capturing existing trade unions would enable the communist parties to command the working masses. Despite a year of preparatory work through the Provisional Council,

the RILU founded in 1921 could not claim a single dominant national trade union organization in the West. Such unions remained loyal to the IFTU or independent. A variety of smaller, separately organized unions had affiliated with Moscow, but in 1921 the RILU represented perhaps eight million workers,⁴⁵ and the embarrassing fact remained that at least two-thirds and probably more of these were members of a single affiliate, the All-Russian Trade Unions. The united front, in short, was an attempt to put the communists more fully in touch with the wider working masses, to rebuild the bridges that the communists had destroyed in 1919. This would require among other things an approach to the social democrats in the West. Many western communists, taught to revile and combat the social democrats as traitors, found the tactics of the united front bewildering and initially resisted them, but it was not the last time the Bolsheviks would find a dialectical defense for the expediency of a *volte-face*.

The Bolsheviks, moreover, never intended the united front to justify organic unity with their social democratic or other adversaries in the workers' movement. "The united front," one historian has written, "was a device, an expedient, a contrivance."⁴⁶ It was so on several levels. First, the policy of the united front was intended to be temporary, sanctioning joint action in the labour movement in a non-revolutionary period, but to be abandoned the moment circumstances again radicalized the workers.⁴⁷ Second, by enthroning a purported policy of workers' unity at the centre of the CI's program, the united front would relieve the communists of the stigma they had felt keenly since 1919 as the splitters of the workers' movement. Third, the communist parties were to retain complete independence of action and criticism within the united front. The tactics of the united front called for setting aside the ultimate goals that separated the communists from social democratic and other leaders of the labour movement. Unity of action should rest upon a series of immediate, transitional goals on which all workers could agree. If the non-communist leaders declined to collaborate, they would be seen as the self-serving enemies of united labour action. If they agreed, the communists would gain greater access to the working masses, before whom they could demonstrate their dedication to the cause of labour, their revolutionary commitment and zeal. Throughout such united action the communists were never to surrender their right to criticize non-communist leaders and to pursue their own goals. For the ultimate objective of the united front was not to unify all workers in the pursuit of certain limited objectives, but to enable the communist parties to escape their isolation in a bid for command of the entire movement.

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"We have entered on this road not because we want to merge with the social democrats," as Karl Radek succinctly explained it, "but in the knowledge that we shall smother them in our embrace."⁴⁸

Although one of the slogans of the third CI congress in 1921 – 'To the Masses!' – already epitomized the need for communist parties in the West to escape their isolation, the policy of the united front was formally introduced by the CI Executive only in December 1921. One of the earliest and most dramatic applications of the policy came at the highest level of the workers' movement. A conference in Berlin in April 1922 brought together representatives of the revived Second International, the CI, and the Vienna Union. The Vienna Union was also known as the Two-and-a-Half International, because it had been formed by various European socialist parties that found neither the reformism of the Second International nor the dictatorial propensities of the CI satisfactory. The animosity between the delegates of the CI and those of the Second International was such that the conference dissolved in recriminations, and the CI soon withdrew from a committee set up to pursue negotiations further. The CI nevertheless claimed that these unseemly events had the merit of demonstrating to the workers that the social democrats were the true schismatics. The communists would continue to pursue the united front on a national and local level.

The program of the united front endorsed by the CI Executive in December 1921 extended not only to social democrats, but also to "workers supporting anarcho-syndicalist organizations."⁴⁹ That did not prevent the communists, however, from reacting sharply to the widespread syndicalist hostility to the new RILU. The united front provided the communists with a valuable propaganda device, a slogan of unity, within the international labour movement. They continued to work within the syndicalist unions, whose more recalcitrant leaders they bitterly condemned, for communist doctrine held that resistance to Moscow's policies was attributable only to misled or traitorous leaders, and not the will of their followers. Once the syndicalist support upon which the RILU leaders had counted appeared to be slipping away, therefore, a series of Moscow-sponsored periodicals mounted a counterattack.⁵⁰ Heinrich Brandler, a member of the Executive Committee of the CI, an official in the RILU, and former head of the German Communist Party, summed up the communist interpretation of events. The RILU and the CI, Brandler stated, had assumed the Latin syndicalists to be revolutionary and readily incorporable into the international struggle for the dictatorship of the proletariat. But syndicalist activities in France and Italy had compelled a radical revision of this assumption.

Most syndicalist delegates at the RILU congress, Brandler claimed, had declared in a personal if not an official capacity for affiliation with the RILU, and had promised to work toward that end. Despite the immense patience of the communists, Brandler wrote, they now discovered the anti-politicism of the Latin syndicalists to be increasing instead of declining. In France, he pointed out, the CGTU Executive – in a scarcely veiled indictment of the Soviet regime – had condemned the persecution of militants not only by capitalist governments, but by any government whatever. Although the CGTU had not joined the RILU, Brandler also condemned its domestic policies as incompatible with those endorsed by the RILU and the communists. The CGTU and the USI had both called for the annulment of the RILU statutes requiring an exchange of representatives between the RILU and the CI. This was no question of mere form, Brandler asserted, but a declaration of war upon "the communist conception of the proletarian tasks of the class struggle." Consequently, "this question ceases to be debatable." If the syndicalists were becoming the witting or unwitting instruments of counter-revolution, the communists were obliged to spearhead the battle against them. Another possibility was that the syndicalist form their own International. If they did so, and could actually repel capitalist aggression by methods "they consider revolutionary and we consider defective," nothing need prevent communists and syndicalists from cooperating, even if they were in separate organizations. But a separate syndicalist International was the last thing the RILU wanted, and Brandler quickly indicated that his suggestion was not intended seriously by recommending that the communist parties of France, Italy and Spain launch an immediate anti-syndicalist campaign. This would serve as an ideal prelude to the next congresses of the CI and the RILU, where the attitude towards the syndicalists would have to be seriously reconsidered and clarified.⁵¹

The syndicalists pushed ahead with their own plans. An international assembly had long been pondered, even before the RILU congress itself had disbanded. The small international gathering in Düsseldorf in October had called for a congress in Germany for the spring of 1922. The USI also called for a conference, with the support of the CGTU, at its own annual congress in March 1922.⁵² A circular from the Italians announced that a conference would meet in Paris in mid-May. The circular extended not only to the various syndicalist organizations of Europe, and North and South America, but noted that the Russian trade unions and the Russian syndicalist minority would also be invited. The conference was eventually rescheduled for Berlin in June.⁵³

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On the eve of the conference a *Bulletin International des Syndicalistes Révolutionnaires et Industrialistes* appeared. Rudolf Rocker's hand was evident in the new publication, which among other things responded to the communist press campaign against the syndicalists. Events in Russia, the *Bulletin* maintained, demonstrated that political parties could conquer political power, but were wholly unable to transform the economic and social structure of society. The purported need to seize the state apparatus and maintain it during a transitional period, rested upon "an absolutely incorrect hypothesis and upon an ideology of purely bourgeois origin." The *Bulletin* also challenged communist insistence upon a single front of workers. The labour movement, if progressive, incorporated groups and tendencies varying in their degree of development. Just as individuals passed through distinct evolutionary stages, the mass workers' movement divided into diverse units differing in their stage of development. The assumption that a unified proletariat had immense power held only for a period of struggle when workers were united in their goals. In a period of calm an artificial unity among differing groups could only paralyze "the liberating ideas of the working class." Had not the great majority of German workers been united in the centralist unions before the war? But "*that unity signified simply the spiritual death of the movement and the total impossibility of action.*" Only the independently organized syndicalists, who rejected an artificial and paralyzing unity, opposed the war when it came. Only in the revolutionary will could the key to workers' unity be found; an artificial unity stifled revolutionary zeal. Had the recent emergence of the CGTU not demonstrated that the majority of French workers preferred schism to a false unity? The *Bulletin* argued that reformist unions and Bolsheviks were equally guilty of positing a false unity of the labour movement. The unedifying sight of politicians of various persuasions, who had recently gathered around the same table in Berlin in an attempt to unite the Second, the Two-and-a-Half, and the Third Internationals, demonstrated that leaders of reformist unions and political parties promoted an artificial organizational unity to augment their power over the masses. In contrast, the syndicalists denied that unity could be achieved by politicians aspiring "to exercise power *over* the workers. A true single front of the proletariat can be established only by the exclusion of all political parties." The Bolsheviks demonstrated their attitude toward unity by brutally persecuting and suppressing revolutionary groups within their own country. Since unity in the revolutionary struggle demanded some degree of mutual tolerance, the tactic of the Russian Communist Party

ought to be stigmatized as reactionary. The existence of several revolutionary groups does not paralyze revolutionary efforts, but, on the contrary, by the free play of forces which free association renders possible, revolutionary initiative is greatly increased.⁵⁴

How, the *Bulletin* asked, should the syndicalists respond on the international question? The RILU pursued its Janus-like policy toward western syndicalists, treating them as brothers-in-arms with whom an accord should be reached and simultaneously denouncing them as counter-revolutionary enemies of the workers. "In one hand the olive branch, in the other the bloody sword." The *Bulletin* argued that even if after their impending conference the syndicalists made a last attempt to reach an accord with the communists, by entering the RILU on the condition that both its federalist and its centralist "branches" retained liberty of action, an international Syndicalist Bureau would still be a necessary counterweight to the directing organ of the centralist branch, namely, the CI. Alternatively, if they refused to join the RILU or if the latter's repudiation of autonomy made unity impossible, a Bureau would be necessary to unify the syndicalists and to prepare for a truly revolutionary International. Whatever course they chose, then, it would be tantamount to "suicide" if the imminent syndicalist conference failed to establish a syndicalist Bureau.⁵⁵ Bouwman's prophecy in Moscow that the failure of the RILU congress to take the Berlin conference seriously, and to treat the syndicalists less dogmatically, would lead to the formation of a second revolutionary labour International, appeared to be moving towards fulfillment.

For domestic reasons neither the Dutch NAS nor the Portuguese CGT attended the syndicalists' June conference in Berlin.⁵⁶ A CGTU delegation appeared, but declined to vote on issues before the conference, pointing out that only the first congress of the CGTU, soon to be held in St. Etienne, could determine the policy of the new organization. The situation in France had changed considerably since the break with the CGT. The early libertarian predominance in the CGTU had increasingly been challenged not only by the communist faction centred around Tommasi, Rosmer, Godonnèche and *La Lutte de Classe*, but more importantly by the syndicalists grouped around Monatte, Monmousseau, and *La Vie Ouvrière*. The latter had recovered from their earlier indecisiveness, their rift with Moscow, and were preparing a bid to wrest the new CGTU from the libertarians and to imprint it with their own policies. On the eve of the St. Etienne congress it remained uncertain what policy the CGTU would adopt towards Moscow.

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If the pro-RILU forces were experiencing a resurgence in France, across the Pyrenees they were suffering a gradual but unquestionable rout in the CNT. At the 1919 Comedia congress, the identification of the *cenetistas* with the Russian Revolution and the esteem extended to the Bolsheviks had been all but unassailable. By June 1922 the prestige of the Bolsheviks had plummeted. The authoritarian character of the Soviet regime and the centralizing dictates of the CI had become abundantly clear. In August 1921, in the wake of the RILU congress, a plenum had categorically reiterated the independence of the CNT from any political party, its self-sufficiency in preparing and realizing social revolution, and its commitment to the ultimate goal of libertarian communism. It deferred judgment concerning the conduct of the CNT delegates to the RILU congress, however, until their return.⁵⁷ Return was not easy. Shortly after the plenum Joaquin Maurin and Jesus Ibanez were detained in Germany *en route* to Spain. Eventually released, they made their way home, where Ibanez was arrested. Nin, Arlandis and Leval, following a little later, were also incarcerated in Germany. Upon their release, Arlandis and Leval continued on to Spain, only to be arrested again. Nin preferred to return from Germany to Russia to offer his services to the RILU. He would remain there throughout the 1920's, a zealous supporter of the Bolsheviks and a talented and very valuable officer in the hierarchy of communist internationalism. In October 1921, then, when a new plenum of the CNT met in Barcelona to consider the report of its RILU delegation, only Maurin was available to address it. Even the CNT's 1920 delegate to Russia, Angel Pestaña, remained in prison. The assembly therefore heard only a very favourable report on the RILU and events in Russia from Maurin, the man who had replaced Nin as the Secretary of the National Committee. The majority at this misunderstood plenum⁵⁸ voted to postpone any decision on the RILU until the local unions could discuss the issues, which would be no easy task in the repressive conditions in which the CNT operated.

But although one Spanish communist-syndicalist, Andres Nin, now stood at the right hand of Lozovskii in Russia, and another, Joaquin Maurin, headed its National Committee, the CNT was not to be won for Moscow. The tide had begun to move inexorably against the communist-syndicalists, the October plenum providing them at best a brief respite, a final period of grace. However difficult the dissemination of the results of the RILU congress in Spain, the more widely they became known, the greater the opposition to Moscow grew. In reviews such as Federico Urales's *La Revista Blanca*, moreover, in periodicals like *Tierra y Libertad* in Barcelona, *Nueva Senda* in Madrid, and

Redencion in Alcoy, the increasingly critical writings concerning Russia by such well-known foreign anarchists as Malatesta in Italy, Jean Grave in France, Rocker in Germany, and Goldman and Berkman, found quick and sympathetic outlet, and were buttressed by the criticisms of respected native anarchists, among them José Prat and Urales. Even more important in prompting a critical reappraisal among *cenetistas* of their attitude toward Moscow, was the long-delayed publication of Pestaña's report of his 1920 mission to Russia. Written in prison, published in pamphlet form by *Nueva Senda* in November 1921, Pestaña's critical *Memorias* bore the prestige of one of the CNT's most highly revered leaders.⁵⁹ The fact that forceful, repressive action by the government had succeeded in crippling the CNT, moreover, had undermined the earlier revolutionary expectations of the *cenetistas*. These factors all contributed to the re-emergence and accentuation of the anarcho-syndicalist principles that were the mainstays of *cenetista* ideology. News of the decisions taken in the RILU congress, now increasingly served only to heighten the reaction against Moscow, and to reinforce *cenetista* determination to repudiate the error made in 1919, now seen as an ideological aberration occasioned by the revolutionary enthusiasm fired by the Russian Revolution. Hence only with profound regret and dismay did a leading CNT militant, looking back at the 1919 Comedia congress, declare that although the delegates had not intended to betray their convictions, "the immense majority behaved like true Bolsheviks."⁶⁰

The mounting anti-Moscow sentiment reduced the continuing efforts of the communist-syndicalists on behalf of the RILU to a rearguard action, conducted primarily in the pages of *Lucha Social*. The release of large numbers of previously confined CNT leaders further hindered their efforts. The rapid rise of members of the communist-syndicalist faction, which had been facilitated by the mass arrests, was now reversed, as released militants resumed earlier roles of leadership. Maurin's arrest in February 1922, moreover, left the highest office in the organization vacant. The CNT selected not only a new Secretary General, Juan Peiro, but a new National Committee, whose members described themselves as "essentially anarchists" in a statement of principles in March. The statement endorsed direct action, federalism, libertarian communism, and vowed opposition to all dictatorships and all institutions of the state.⁶¹ A more categorical repudiation of the communist-syndicalists could hardly have been formulated.

The resolution of the international issue within the CNT came in June 1922, at a plenum in Zaragoza, which was somewhat hastily convened, in part to permit the CNT to dispatch a delegation to the

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Berlin conference. The Zaragoza plenum passionately challenged the conduct of the Nin-Maurin delegation in Moscow. Only Arlandis appeared to defend the delegation of which he had been a part. His efforts were in vain. Leval attacked the conduct of his co-delegates in a written report. Pestaña, finally freed, spoke of his experiences in Russia in an address highly critical of Moscow. He went further than he had in earlier written reports, now urging the CNT's withdrawal from the RILU. The plenum endorsed a protest from Galo Diez, the Secretary of the CNT's Northern Region, against the repression of the Russian people by the Soviet regime. Only hesitation over a procedural question, whether a plenum could reverse the decision of a congress, prevented adoption of Manuel Buenacasa's demand for the immediate and complete separation of the CNT from Moscow. In the end, the delegates readily approved the CNT's withdrawal from the Moscow International in principle, proposing a referendum on the question. Conditions prevented the referendum from being held and the Zaragoza meeting marked the final breach between the CNT and Moscow. But before disbanding, the assembly accepted Buenacasa's suggestion immediately to send a delegation to the Berlin conference.⁶² Due to their late departure from Zaragoza, Diez and Avelino Gonzalez-Mallada arrived in Berlin only on the last day of the conference.

The Syndicalists Break With Moscow: The June Conference

The syndicalist organizations represented in the Berlin conference of June 1922 claimed to comprise over 1,400,000 workers. This represented the memberships of the CGTU (represented by Totti, Lecoin and Besnard), the FAUD (Rocker, Kater, Souchy), the USI (Borghi, Bonazzi, Negre), the CNT (Diez, Gonzalez-Mallada), the SAC and the NSF (both represented by Jensen).⁶³ The conference also recognized the deported Mark Mratchnyi, and Alexander Schapiro, visiting from Russia, as delegates of the Russian Syndicalist Minority, and Andrecev, who arrived shortly after the conference had begun, as the representative of the All-Russian Trade Unions. Each country received a single deliberative vote except for Russia, which received two – one for the centralist unions and one for the syndicalist minority. The French delegation announced its abstention from all votes since the imminent St. Etienne congress of the CGTU would itself take up the international issue.

The arrival of the delegate of the All-Russian Trade Unions immediately disrupted the work of the assembly, which had been discussing

the world-wide persecution of revolutionaries. The Italian militants suffered not only from government repression but from marauding bands of fascists. One of the USI delegates, Bonazzi, had been stabbed in his home by fascists the week before the conference.⁶⁴ Earlier, in March 1921, the Milan home of Borghi and his companion, the poet and militant Virgilia D'Andrea, had been burned by fascists.⁶⁵ The delegates had before them a resolution from Schapiro protesting Soviet persecution, when Andreev arrived. In detailing the repression in Russia, Mratchnyi cited examples in which the leaders of the Red trade unions, and the government through the Cheka, had worked together to suppress dissent in the labour movement. If the Red trade unions were "red," Mratchnyi declared, "it is with the blood of the workers and the peasants which they continue to shed in order to preserve their power;" he added that "it is impossible to know where the unions end and where the government or the Cheka begins. I assert that those who are at the head of the [labour] organizations often do the work of the Chekists." These charges drew fiery protests from Andreev, who declared his support for the Russian government. The Russian trade unions, he asserted, supported the terror tactics directed against the bourgeoisie and its agents, regardless of the revolutionary titles they invoked. "We are partisans of the Red Terror and of the dictatorship of the proletariat." He nevertheless demanded to be recognized solely as representing the Russian trade unions, and not the Soviet government, and further insisted that the conference rule Mratchnyi's remarks inadmissible. A number of delegates pointed out that if he represented only the trade unions, he need take no offense at criticisms of the Soviet government. As syndicalists assembled in conference they would not renounce their right to criticize exploitative governments, including the Russian. Andreev further inflamed the situation by turning to the offensive: "You present yourselves as accusers of the Russian government; you demand explanations of it, whereas it is you who should be rendering accounts. What have you done to enable us to establish a truly communist regime? . . . You, the Italians, the French - what have you done for Russia, for its famine?" Armando Borghi quickly retorted that it had been the Italian communists who had undermined the revolution in Italy by transforming it into an electoral question, while Augustin Souchy charged the Bolsheviks with generously subsidizing communist newspapers in every country, instead of directing these funds to the relief of Russian famine victims.⁶⁶

The assembly referred the entire issue to committee, where Andreev found the going no easier than he had in open session. Having heard the delegations of the Russian Syndicalist Minority and the All-Russian

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Trade Unions, the committee put the following questions three times to Andreev:

1. Does the All-Russian Trade Unions accept a formal commitment to demand of the Russian government the release of all syndicalists and anarchists imprisoned for their ideas?
2. Will it further require that these comrades be allowed freely to conduct their revolutionary activities in the unions, on condition that they do not combat the Russian government by force of arms?⁶⁷

Andreev was obviously in a difficult position. The mounting frustration of foreign syndicalists over the persecution of their Russian comrades, the presence of representatives of the oppressed minority, Andreev's defense of the Red Terror, and his own insistence that he represented only the Soviet unions and not the Bolshevik government, had prompted the assembled syndicalists to put the issue as bluntly as possible to Andreev. But the very formulation of the first question – like the classical query, “Have you stopped beating your wife?” – was such that either an affirmative or a negative answer would damn the respondent. Andreev actually answered the first question affirmatively, and the French delegation later invoked his answer as proof that Russian syndicalists and anarchists were imprisoned for their ideas. Andreev declined a direct response to the second question, equivocating at length, until the committee recorded that the All-Russian Trade Unions dissociated itself from the issue.⁶⁸ Andreev's attitude on this question strongly impressed the remaining delegates. For some it constituted the proverbial last straw in their relations with Moscow, a final confirmation of the impossibility of collaboration between revolutionary syndicalists and communists in the RILU. It put the seal to their mounting conviction that they had no choice but to follow their own international course.⁶⁹

Andreev himself soon quit the conference. By obvious prearrangement, the Italian, Nicolo Vecchi, and a German, Wurster, appeared at the next session, demanding admission with Andreev's support as representatives of the USI minority and the *Union Hand- und Kopfarbeiter (Gelsenkirchen)*, a RILU affiliate. In accord with the original conditions of admission, the two were admitted not as delegates, but only as guests.⁷⁰ Still smarting from the confrontation on Soviet repression, Andreev seized this opportunity to abandon the conference. Inveighing against the assembly as sectarian, he turned to the French and Italian delegates to assert that “the RILU will go over the heads of the present leaders of the CGTU and the USI to organize the French and Italian workers' movements according to its own directives,” and stalked out of the

conference with Vecchi and Wurster.⁷¹ With Andreev's departure the assembly adopted no resolution on persecutions at all. The delegates realized that their refusal to seat Vecchi and Wurster had given Andreev, embittered by the issue of persecutions, a pretext for quitting the conference. Certain that the Russians would send a representative to the St. Etienne congress, and cognizant of how near Moscow stood to capturing the CGTU, Totti and Lecoin asked the conference to make a concession to the French by not putting any persecution resolutions to a vote. They feared that a condemnation of the Bolshevik government, given the widespread sympathy for the Russian Revolution in the CGTU, would be exploited against the French libertarians and the Berlin conference. The remaining delegates reluctantly acceded to the request.⁷²

Turning to more constructive work, the assembly accepted a ten-point declaration of the principles and tactics of syndicalism, drafted by Rocker.⁷³ The remainder of its business concerned the organization of an international Bureau and relations with Moscow. The delegates manifested little sympathy for further overtures toward the RILU. Borghi spoke of the conditions the USI had stipulated for a labour International. "With or without Moscow, even against Moscow, revolutionary syndicalism must organize itself." Albert Jensen reported that a SAC referendum had pronounced for an independent syndicalist International. The smaller syndicalist movements of Norway, Denmark and Spitzbergen, he observed, were also overwhelmingly opposed to the RILU. Schapiro envisaged two possibilities of further negotiations with Moscow: the conference could pose minimal conditions that a duplicitous RILU might shrewdly accept, or ones of such severity that the RILU would be certain to refuse them. But the first course would be a betrayal of syndicalism, the second merely a demagogic ploy, "and we can never allow ourselves this Bolshevik luxury." Rather than either negotiating with the RILU or declaring war upon it, Schapiro believed it best if "we will simply continue on our own course." In Rocker's view a syndicalist International was inevitable, "for an existence in common with Moscow will become insufferable even for those who are still filled with false hopes. In the meantime we will lose time and pessimism will infiltrate our ranks." Only the French delegates, the upcoming CGTU congress uppermost in their minds, supported continued negotiations with Moscow, proposing that an alternative set of statutes be drawn up for the consideration of the RILU.⁷⁴

The resolution adopted by the assembly, however, made no mention of further negotiations with the RILU. The principles and statutes of the RILU, the assembly declared, prevented it from welding together

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the revolutionary workers of the world. Consequently a provisional Syndicalist Bureau was to prepare an international congress of revolutionary unions for November. Although the syndicalists could scarcely have believed the RILU would endorse such an invitation, the Bureau was also to communicate the decisions of the present conference to the RILU Executive, in the hope that its affiliates would participate in a congress seeking to establish a single International for all revolutionary unions. The Bureau, headquartered in Berlin, included members from each affiliated country, with Rocker as Bureau Secretary and German representative, Borghi for Italy, Pestaña for Spain, Jensen for the Scandinavian countries, and Schapiro for Russia.⁷⁵

Only during the discussion concerning the Bureau did the Spanish delegation arrive. It put the position of the CNT bluntly. Galo Diez immediately declared the affiliation of the Spanish organization with the RILU to have been the work of a few CNT activists, "a few politicians," who had not consulted the organization's members. Committed to an absolutely autonomous International, the CNT wanted nothing to do with Moscow. Even if every other syndicalist organization joined the RILU, the *cenetistas* would oppose it alone. Advised of the course of the conference, the Spaniards endorsed its resolutions on behalf of the CNT.⁷⁶

On the international level the June conference marked the final rupture between the syndicalists and the communists. Certainly the atmosphere in the conference was far different from that held in Berlin eighteen months earlier. In December 1920, only the doubts of the Swedish and German delegates had been raised against the prevailing enthusiasm for Moscow, and the ardent desire to reach an accord with the communists in the founding congress of the RILU. In the interim there had been the disillusionment with the RILU congress itself, and the controversy it had engendered, including campaigns in the communist press against the more resolute syndicalists and communist cell-building within syndicalist organizations, which had made such bodies as the USI, the CGTU and the NAS, arenas of sharp internecine struggle.⁷⁷ The continuing persecution of libertarians in Russia, moreover, had been abundantly documented, and the syndicalists had witnessed the spectacle of the Soviet regime, purportedly a workers' government, busily deporting revolutionaries. While in some syndicalist unions of Europe, notably the NAS and the CGTU, the question of international allegiance had not yet been resolved, by June 1922 the SAC, the FAUD, the USI, and the CNT, had called for the formation of an independent syndicalist International. In so doing, the USI and the CNT had demonstrated

how premature and ill-founded had been the Bolsheviks' earlier delight in their apparent victories in Italy and Spain. The June conference indicated in a number of ways the definitive nature of the international breach between syndicalists and communists. The final resolution made no provision for mutual negotiations between the syndicalists and the RILU, and stipulated no changes in the RILU as the price required to ransom syndicalist support. The conference, in short, rejected the RILU as a failure beyond redemption. The assembled delegates, moreover, christened the June meeting a 'Preliminary Conference'; that is, they declared it a step toward the establishment of an autonomous revolutionary labour International.

The conference's declaration of principles perhaps most compellingly demonstrated the irrevocable character of the break. The document amounted to an unequivocal assertion that the major lesson of the Russian Revolution was the need for a forceful reaffirmation of syndicalist principles. The declaration rejected political parties, parliamentarism, militarism, nationalism and centralism; it endorsed the absolute autonomy of economically militant organizations uniting manual and intellectual workers; direct action; the federalist organization of economic and social life; the abolition of all state functions in society; and the ultimate goal of a voluntarily organized free communism. If the unequivocal anti-statism of the declaration were not sufficient to distinguish the syndicalist position, the principles expressly repudiated the proletarian dictatorship enshrined in Bolshevik ideology. While two or three years earlier, in the full flush of revolutionary enthusiasm, many European syndicalists were prepared to seek some accommodation with the idea and practice of the dictatorship, to sing its praises, and to hail Lenin's *State and Revolution* as a revelatory document, those gathered in Berlin in 1922 were unanimous in pronouncing the dictatorship of the proletariat an indisputable evil, incompatible with their doctrine. The second point of the credo they endorsed insisted

that together with the monopoly of property, the monopoly of power must also vanish, and that the state in every form, even in the form of the so-called 'Dictatorship of the Proletariat', can never be an instrument for the liberation of labour, but always only the creator of new monopolies and privileges.

In introducing the resolution to the assembly, Rocker declared the proposition advanced by Engels and accepted by Lenin ("and a certain number of syndicalists"), that the state would disappear with the disappearance of classes, to be "nothing more than a sophism masking the facts." The establishment of a Bolshevik "commissarocracy" in

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Russia had demonstrated that the state could serve not only to defend existing classes, but also to create new privileged strata in society. In reality, nothing imperilled a revolution more than dictatorship. Syndicalists, Rucker asserted, were enemies of dictatorship precisely because they were partisans of revolution.⁷⁷

Since the dictatorship had been endorsed throughout the RILU's statutes, its repudiation in Berlin made a *rapprochement* between the RILU and the syndicalists all but impossible. But the Russian experience had not only instructed the syndicalists in the source of threats to a revolution, it had also taught them how immensely complicated would be the task of making their principles prevail on the chaotic morrow of revolution, a point that Mratchnyi and Schapiro, who had witnessed the Russian revolutionary drama first-hand, took pains to emphasize. Thus in endorsing direct action, the syndicalists eschewed an easy reliance upon the efficacy of the general strike. The declaration of principles described the "social general strike" as the highest expression of direct action, but also pointed out that it constituted only the "prelude to the social revolution." But here too the syndicalists directly condemned the Bolshevik tactic, for they described themselves as "enemies of all organized violence in the hands of any revolutionary government." They recognized that the revolution would require a violent defense, but the administration of that defense should remain completely in the hands of the people themselves, through their economic organizations. Any other course would jeopardize the entire revolution. The defense of the revolution must "be entrusted to the masses themselves and their economic organizations, and not left to a specific military organization, or any other organization, that stands outside the economic associations."⁷⁸

The declaration of principles did not constitute a radical departure in revolutionary thought, and indeed many syndicalists argued that the lamentable course of the Russian Revolution had confirmed the legitimacy of their existing doctrine and strategy. And yet it did mark a significant shift in syndicalist thinking, for it formalized and made explicit what was often only implicit in the syndicalism of pre-war Europe, by endorsing not merely the political neutrality expressed in the *Charte d'Amiens*, but opposition to all political parties - viewed now as distinct rival organizations that inevitably sought to control or subordinate the unions - and the destruction of the political state around which the activities of the parties revolved. In short, the document sanctioned by the delegates in Berlin elaborated anarcho-syndicalist principles. It was therefore reminiscent of the more rudimentary dec-

laration endorsed in London in 1913, although the tenor the 1922 declaration took was more importantly and inevitably the result of the Russian experience, and the effort of the Bolsheviks to establish their hegemony over the whole of the revolutionary movement. For the declaration that won unanimous support in Berlin, and whose principles the French, despite their abstention, declared it their duty to defend in St. Etienne, was more than a reaffirmation of faith; it was also a defiant declaration of independence from Moscow. The voices of syndicalist dissent, few and scattered two years earlier, had become a chorus. The syndicalists had finally and irrevocably rejected the CI and its appendage, the RILU. The communist bid to reap a mass harvest of syndicalist support had failed. Six months later the same declaration of principles would be unanimously adopted as that of a new syndicalist International.

The CGTU and a Bolshevik Concession

The June conference demonstrated that the majority of European syndicalist organizations lay beyond the grasp of Moscow, and that the foundation of a syndicalist International was therefore almost inevitable. And yet there remained a very important prize to win: the CGTU. For Moscow the CGTU was particularly important. While the RILU's chief rival, the Amsterdam International, claimed a large number of affiliates that were the largest trade union organizations in their respective countries, very few significant independently organized labour associations outside Russia had joined the RILU. Many supporters of the Moscow International, unlike the All-Russian Trade Unions, were in fact minority groups within organizations affiliated with the IFTU in Amsterdam. The RILU could not claim a single affiliate in western Europe, except in Norway, that constituted the major trade union organization of its nation. Moscow desperately wanted such an affiliate in France, not only because the CGTU appeared to be the heir to France's long and important revolutionary tradition, but also to secure a further outpost in western Europe to legitimate the RILU's claim to be a truly international labour organization, capable of rivalling the IFTU. But Moscow, alarmed by the early ascendancy of the libertarians in the councils of the CGTU, feared that it had not only lost the CGT but would also lose the CGTU. The CGTU Administrative Committee's sharp assertion of its anti-statist attitude in March 1922, its opposition to all governments and political parties, and its implicit criticism of

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the Bolsheviks' persecution of Russian revolutionaries, demonstrated that such fears were well-grounded.

The Bolsheviks made a concerted effort to counter this threat, acting long range from Moscow – from which money, directives, guidelines, public and private arguments and cajolery, flowed into the French labour movement – and also demanding much more vigorous action on the spot from the PCF, whose inactivity and timidity towards the trade unions they impatiently condemned. These various efforts began to bear fruit in the pivotal month of May. On 4 May, Lozovskii complained to Rosmer in Paris that nothing had been done to prepare for the congress of St. Etienne, in which the libertarians threatened to prevail. "A meticulous preparation for the congress must be undertaken, resolutions must be elaborated in advance, disseminated, etc. A series of articles must be published in *L'Humanité* in the name of the RILU, on each point of the agenda a tract or a little brochure must be produced."⁷⁹ On 5 May the Russian-sponsored *La Lutte de Classe* appeared in France, to combat the libertarians and to rally support within the CGTU for the RILU. Directed by Rosmer, *La Lutte de Classe* spoke for the communist-syndicalist faction, which preferred that the CGTU accept the RILU statutes as originally elaborated. But the communist-syndicalist spokesmen, no less than the Bolsheviks closely monitoring the situation from Moscow, realized that they lacked support for this decision at St. Etienne. Their only hope lay in reaching an accord with the larger and more influential group of syndicalists centred around *La Vie Ouvrière*, who, though largely uncritical supporters of the Russian Revolution and of Moscow, opposed the subordinating statutes of the RILU as they stood. The communist-syndicalists were more than willing to make concessions to build a bloc with the faction of *La Vie Ouvrière*, lest the CGTU be lost entirely to them and enrolled in a syndicalist International. From Moscow Lozovskii had long been urging such a combination upon the *Vie Ouvrière* faction, prodding them to make common cause with the communist-syndicalists against the libertarians, as the only means of saving the CGTU from ruin.⁸⁰ May also saw the return of Monatte to labour activism. In despair over the schism in the CGT, which he had failed to convince Monmousseau and others of *La Vie Ouvrière* to oppose at all costs, Monatte had resigned from the paper and remained silent for months. On 10 May, he ended his self-imposed silence by publishing a sharp attack on the libertarians, not in *La Vie Ouvrière*, significantly, but in the paper of the PCF, *L'Humanité*. On 12 May the CI Executive wrote to the PCF to demand more direct and vigorous action in the unions.⁸¹ In May, too, the CI's agent and leading trouble-

shooter in western Europe, Jules Humbert-Droz, arrived in Paris. By the end of the month *La Vie Ouvrière* had issued its own program in opposition to the more markedly libertarian statutes proposed by the CGTU's Administrative Committee, and Humbert-Droz could advise Moscow that "the pure syndicalists (Verdier, Quinton, etc.) are now outside the party. The trade union commission of the party is functioning and has reached agreement with the Monmousseau faction in order to carry the struggle against the allied anarchists and pure syndicalists."⁸²

By the end of May, then, the union of communists and pro-Moscow syndicalists that Lozovskii regarded as essential had already begun to coalesce. When the CGTU Executive announced plans to participate in the June conference in Berlin, it therefore drew fire from both quarters. Lozovskii himself also intervened to challenge the right of the libertarian leaders of the CGTU to participate in the Berlin meetings, suggesting that the libertarians at its head wished to present the CGTU membership with a *fait accompli* in international relations. The Administrative Committee replied that the CGTU intended to participate in the Berlin conference in an informational capacity, before determining its own national and international orientation, and that it did not require the permission of the RILU to do so. Given their purpose, the CGTU representatives would neither vote nor undertake formal commitments in Berlin. Following the delegation's departure in mid-June, Monmousseau blasted the decision of the majority on the Administrative Committee as a ruse to lead the congress of St. Etienne into "the International of Borghi, Schapiro and Souchy."⁸³ The position of the libertarians was also damaged by the fact that the secret *Pacte* of February 1921, whereby a group of them had established a committee to put at the leadership of the CSR those who were "purely revolutionary syndicalists, autonomists and federalists,"⁸⁴ was made public, also in mid-June.

In accord with its mandate the CGTU delegation voted for none of the resolutions endorsed in Berlin, though its mere presence there would be invoked against it. Similarly, its fears that the withdrawal of the Russian delegation would be exploited, both against the conference and against the libertarians in the CGTU, were quickly realized. Two days before the St. Etienne congress, Andreev, Vecchi and Wurster, denounced the Berlin conference in *La Vie Ouvrière*. They claimed that the exclusion of those groups represented by Wurster and Vecchi ("the most important group" in the USI), proved that the conference had no intention of trying to unite all syndicalist organizations. The Berlin assembly had sought instead to undermine a single revolutionary trade unionist front by forming a new labour International dominated by anarchist sects.

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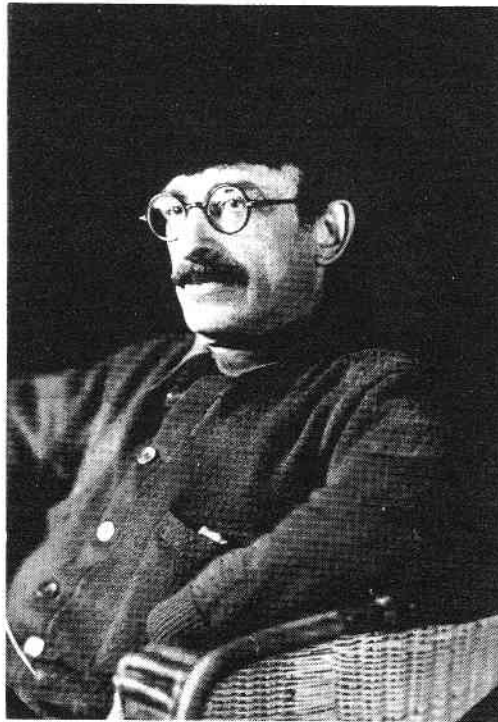
Andreev and his colleagues predicted that the syndicalist organizations would nevertheless find a way to unite with the revolutionary Russian unions in the RILU.⁸⁵

Maurice Chambelland, a *La Vie Ouvrière* stalwart who had attended the conference but left when Andreev withdrew, counter-signed the statement. The same issue of *La Vie Ouvrière* carried Chambelland's lengthy critique, dismissing the conference as an enterprise of international schism convoked by the "most determined adversaries of the RILU and the Russian Revolution." But while Andreev had been careful not to mention the persecution issue explicitly, Chambelland emphasized it, and likely for tactical reasons. Although the libertarian wing of the CGTU had grown increasingly critical of developments in Russia, extensive support and sympathy for the Russian Revolution survived within the organization. To portray the libertarians as enemies of the Revolution provided their opponents with a powerful weapon. In discussing the role of the Russian Minority in the conference, Chambelland wrote:

The trial of the Russian Revolution began! It seems moreover that this was the principal object of the conference, if one judges by the ardour that Schapiro, Borghi, Souchy and Lecoin - the latter a consultative delegate! - exhibited in swooping upon the delegation of the Russian [Trade Union] Central, which was roundly abused.

Chambelland accused Lecoin of exceeding his mandate in this respect, and the entire French delegation of having done so by supporting the exclusion of Vecchi. The St. Etienne congress, he added ominously, would take note of this. Though he had left the conference before the discussion of the agenda had even begun, Chambelland recorded that the conference had probably drawn up a completely unacceptable ultimatum to present to the RILU, and that the French delegates had violated their mandate by supporting it. Although it existed only in Chambelland's imagination, he proceeded to denounce this "manoeuvre" of the French delegation.⁸⁶

The charge that the French delegation had exceeded its mandate in Berlin inevitably arose at the St. Etienne congress,⁸⁷ along with the accusation that the Berlin conference had initiated its work by indicting the Russian Revolution. Nor was the attack upon the June conference conducted solely by its French opponents. Schapiro had predicted in Berlin that the RILU would make apparent concessions at the CGTU congress, that it would promise the CGTU its autonomy, that it would "throw one or two bones to the syndicalist Cerberus."⁸⁸ Lozovskii himself



Three libertarian deportees. Above: Alexander Berkman in Moscow in 1920, following his expulsion from the USA. Below: Gregorii and Olga Maximoff in Paris in 1925, three years after their expulsion from Russia.



*Prima fila
Seconda fila
Terza fila
Quarta fila*

Some of the members of the RILF in the summer of 1925, when they moved into the RILF building. On the far left is Piero...

La minoranza Sind. Riv. a Saint-Etienne.



Prima fila: 1 Olive, — 3 Ferandol, — 4 Raitzon, — 5 Chevalier — 5 Seigné, — 7 Veber ecc.
 Seconda fila: 1 Boudoux, — 2 Batt, — Sebastien Faure, — 4 Diez, delegato spagnolo, 6 Fourcade,
 8 Dejoukere ecc.
 Terza fila: 1 Forre, — 2 Du Bief, — 3 e 4 Negro e Borghi dell'U.S.I., — 5 Besnard, — 6 Labrousse,
 10 Barthes.
 Quarta fila: 1 Forgués, — 2 Quinton, — 3 Petibon, — 4 Tatti, — 5 La Goujette, — 7 Argence ecc.

Some of the minority delegates and guests at the St. Etienne congress of the French CGTU in the summer of 1922. The syndicalist minority failed to prevent the CGTU's entry into the RILU. Second row, fourth from the left, is the Italian Armando Borghi. On his left is Pierre Besnard, and between them, one row back, is the Spaniard Galo Diez.

1920, following
 in 1925, three

carried the bones from Moscow to St. Etienne. In a written message he assured the French that the organic link between the unions and the communist party was not mandatory, that each country remained free to determine this relationship itself. In a dramatic personal appearance, Lozovskii emotionally defended the RILU and remonstrated against the Berlin conference, before vanishing to foil the French police.⁸⁹ Armando Borghi and Galo Diez, present as fraternal delegates of the USI and the CNT respectively, spoke in defense of the Berlin meetings. Both pointed out that their unions had adhered to the CI in solidarity with the Russian Revolution, before they had realized the statist and dictatorial character the Bolsheviks would give it. As Borghi put it, "we had embraced the shadow of Moscow." Both called for an autonomous revolutionary International toward which they considered the Berlin meetings a first step. To counter Lozovskii's address, Borghi pointed to the disparity between it and the position taken in communist literature and the theses and resolutions of Moscow. He also attempted to neutralize the recurrent implication that those who opposed Moscow were opponents of the Revolution. The Italian syndicalists, he declared, did not condemn revolutions simply because they lacked a syndicalist character, but they also would not abandon their right to criticize. "We are neither the enemies nor the judges of the Russian Revolution; but neither are we blind men who want to ignore the truth."⁹⁰

The libertarian wing of the CGTU, however, was fighting a losing battle. The two main resolutions offered on the international question were those of Monmousseau and Besnard. Monmousseau's called for adherence to the RILU, provided its statutes respected the autonomy of French syndicalism, and spoke against article eleven (directing the RILU to send representatives to the CI Executive) in particular. Besnard's called for a labour International completely independent of any international political organization, expressly repudiated an exchange of representatives such as that adopted between the RILU and the CI, and urged the CGTU to work toward an independent International by sending delegates both to the second congress of the RILU and the syndicalist congress proposed by the Berlin Bureau appointed in June. During the congress the more than 130 delegates who were members of the *Parti Communiste Français*, and who controlled 300 votes, were assembled and instructed to support Monmousseau's motion, though many were partisans of the *Vie Ouvrière* group anyway. The alliance of the communists and the Monatte-Monmousseau group, above all, determined the course of the congress, particularly since support for

the libertarian wing of the Russian Revolution of 1921. Monmousseau's proposal, Besnard's, and the CGTU's rejection of its new Executive of the *Vie Ouvrière* group jubilantly marked the party."⁹¹

The defeat of the libertarian wing led into the CGTU's internal opposition. A minority of the CGTU insisted that the CGTU should not be influenced by those who have just come from outside the national political arena, particularly the syndicalists. They declared agreement with the Syndicalist International Congress and discount the influence of the immediate revolutionary situation. They be attacked the CGTU's *manité*, *La Vie Ouvrière*, and continuing the CGTU's

The CGTU's In the second congress of the CGTU assembly under the statute of the CGTU agreements with the syndicalists and to organize the CGTU not substantially "unconditionally" in every country measures."⁹²

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the libertarians had been eroded by their characterization as enemies of the Russian Revolution, and by the earlier revelation of the *Pacte* of 1921. Monmousseau's motion secured 743 votes to 406 for Besnard's proposal. By a similar margin, the statutes Monmousseau proposed for the CGTU were carried over those moved by Besnard. The composition of its new Bureau put the guidance of the CGTU wholly in the hands of the *Vie Ouvrière* group.⁹¹ "The vote at St. Etienne," Humbert-Droz jubilantly reported to the CI, "is indisputably a brilliant victory for the party."⁹²

The defeated minority vowed to combat the introduction of politics into the CGTU, which they believed Monmousseau's resolutions represented. A *Comité de Defense Syndicaliste* (CDS) soon appeared as an internal opposition within the CGTU. It sought to organize resistance at every level in a bid to reconquer the CGTU. The CDS therefore insisted that the individuals and groups supporting it remain within the CGTU. "Syndicalism cannot be wrested from the hands of those who have just led it to the deceitful abdication of St. Etienne by struggling from outside, by quitting the CGTU." The CDS articulated an international policy as well. Since the syndicalist organizations elsewhere, particularly those of Italy, Spain, Germany, and Scandinavia, had declared against the RILU, the CDS would enter into close relations with the Syndicalist Bureau in Berlin, which it considered "an International Committee of Syndicalist Defense."⁹³ Though he professed to discount the importance of the CDS, an angry Lozovskii called for its immediate destruction. Writing to Monatte, he insisted that the CDS be attacked "with fixed bayonets," that not a single issue of *L'Humanité*, *La Vie Ouvrière*, or *La Lutte de Classe* appear without continuing the assault.⁹⁴

The CGTU leadership proceeded to fulfill the directives of St. Etienne. In the second congress of the RILU that opened in Moscow in November, the CGTU requested, the RILU Executive recommended, and the assembly unanimously accepted, a resolution replacing article eleven of the statutes with one permitting the RILU Executive to make agreements with the CI Executive, to hold joint meetings, to issue appeals and to organize combined actions with it. The changes were obviously not substantial. The very resolution embodying them affirmed the "unconditional necessity of the leading role of the communist party in every country and of the Communist International in international measures."⁹⁵ The CGTU nevertheless accepted this gesture as satisfactory and declared its intention to join the RILU.⁹⁶

The decisions taken in the second congress concerning article eleven

also had repercussions in The Netherlands, where the international debate had continued to reverberate through the NAS. The referendum being conducted within the NAS, while the June conference met in Berlin, involved three options and proved inconclusive.⁹⁷ In a second referendum the majority declared that the NAS should not enter the RILU, but join instead with those labour associations that accepted the Berlin Declaration of 1920, in an independent revolutionary trade union International. The third point of the resolution observed that should the RILU "be prepared to assume an autonomous and independent character, the NAS is willing to work for the merger of both Internationals in a world organization of the revolutionary union movement."⁹⁸

News that the RILU assembly had stricken article eleven, however, immediately raised the problem of interpreting the third point of the resolution. The NAS Executive had long been split on the international question, with the pro-Moscow group in the minority. The latter now argued that the alteration in the RILU statutes invalidated the results of the referendum. Bernard Lansink Jr. and others, on the other hand, maintained the change to be one of form only, and certainly not in accord with the spirit of the referendum resolution. The NAS, they held, had no choice but to honour the referendum, and to cooperate in the formation of a revolutionary International on the basis of the Berlin Declaration. The Berlin syndicalist congress was now less than a week away, having been postponed from November to 25 December, to await the results of the second RILU congress. In a special session of the NAS Executive on 20 December, a majority of one supported Thomas Dissel's motion that, in view of the RILU decisions, the NAS affiliate provisionally with Moscow. The resolution directed the NAS delegation to oppose any effort in Berlin to found a separate International. Instead the delegation was to urge the existing Syndicalist Bureau to negotiate with Moscow on a program that could unite all revolutionary unions. The program would be put to the third RILU congress, in which all organizations represented in Berlin would be required to participate. The defeated minority appealed the issue to a meeting of the wider General Council of the NAS the next day. But by abandoning the proposed provisional affiliation with the RILU, the pro-Moscow faction succeeded in carrying the remainder of the resolution. The meeting also selected Jan Schenk and J.G. van Zelm to join Dissel as delegates to Berlin, since Lansink and Carel Wolff had withdrawn from the delegation. The refusal of Lansink and Wolff to carry a mandate they could not approve, meant that the NAS would be formally represented in

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By means of merely cosmetic alterations in the statutes of the RILU, the communists in Moscow had in effect executed a last-minute salvage operation with the NAS. Together with their earlier and more significant success with the CGTU, this constituted some compensation for the earlier loss of the USI and the CNT. But the Bolsheviks sought more than that; above all they wanted to stifle an independent labour International, and they hoped that the changes in the RILU statutes might serve this purpose. The second RILU congress, pointing to its acceptance of the alterations proposed by the CGTU, appealed to syndicalists everywhere to follow the French example by rallying to Moscow. It predicted that whatever their political disposition, the workers would join the RILU, against the will of their leaders if necessary. In particular it urged that the Berlin congress "renounce all attempts to split the international revolutionary labour movement" and join the RILU.¹⁰⁰ But before the end of 1922 an autonomous revolutionary trade union International would be formed, the joint product of syndicalist tenacity and of communist inflexibility.